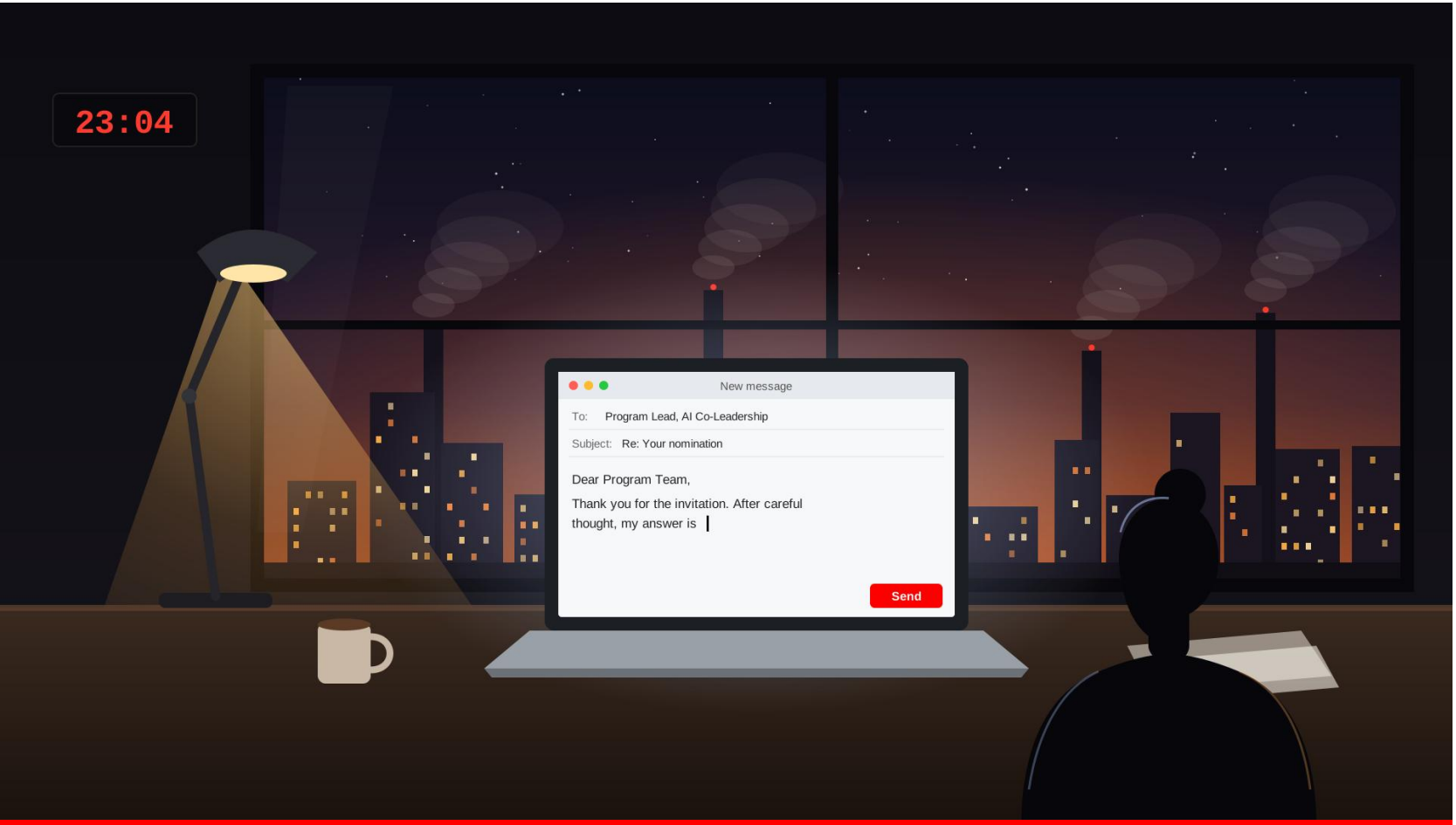
IESE Business School
University of Navarra



Arie's AI Co-Leadership Dilemma: Leading with a Machine in the Room

MiM 2026 · Isabel Villamor

Anything that is in the world when you're born is normal.

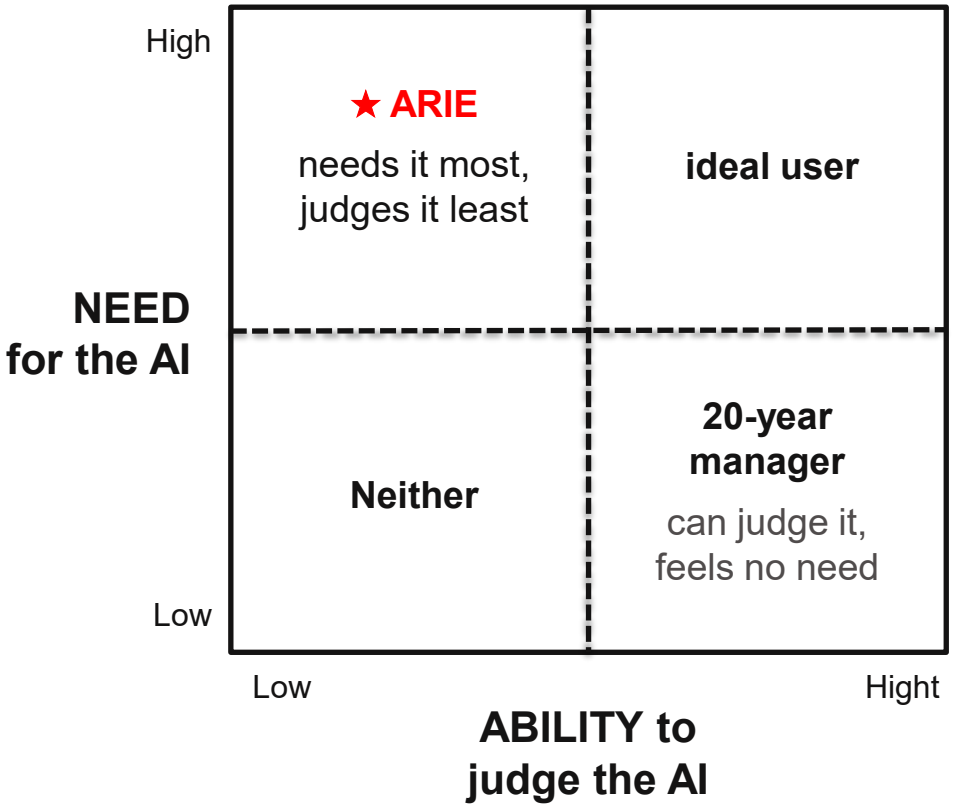
Anything that's invented between when you're 15 and 35 is new and exciting.

Anything invented after you're 35 is the beginning of the end of civilization as we know it.

Douglas Adam´s rules for technology

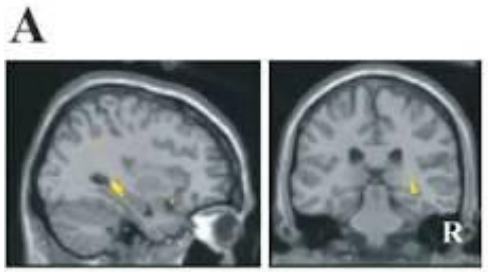
Who should get this AI first?

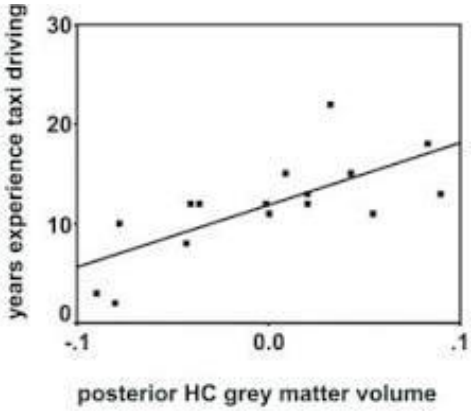
The ironies of automation: **We automate what is easy...** and leave the human the hardest part, taking over when it fails

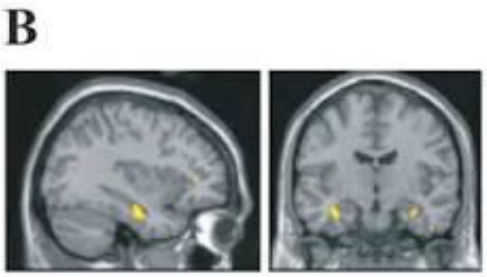


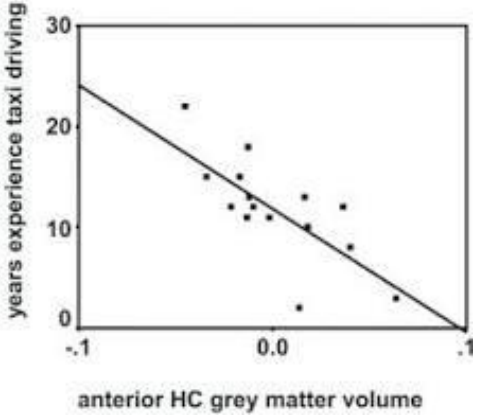
Use it or lose it: the brains of London taxi drivers











The organ that does the job grows with the job.
What happens to the muscle Arie stops using?

Source: Maguire et al. (2000); Maguire et al., (2006)

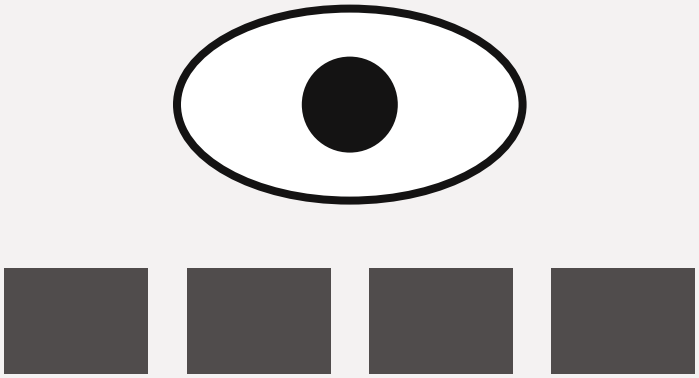
What is she opting into? Six stories, three promises

Operational Awareness

Feedback & Development

Interpersonal Insight

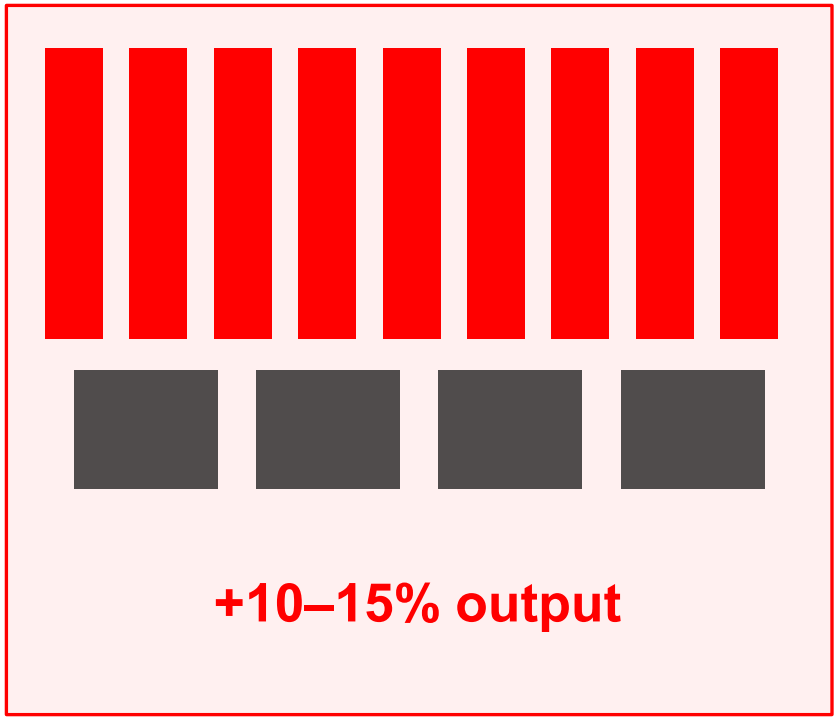
The transparency paradox



WATCHED

→ the official way

“Never do that when they can see you.”

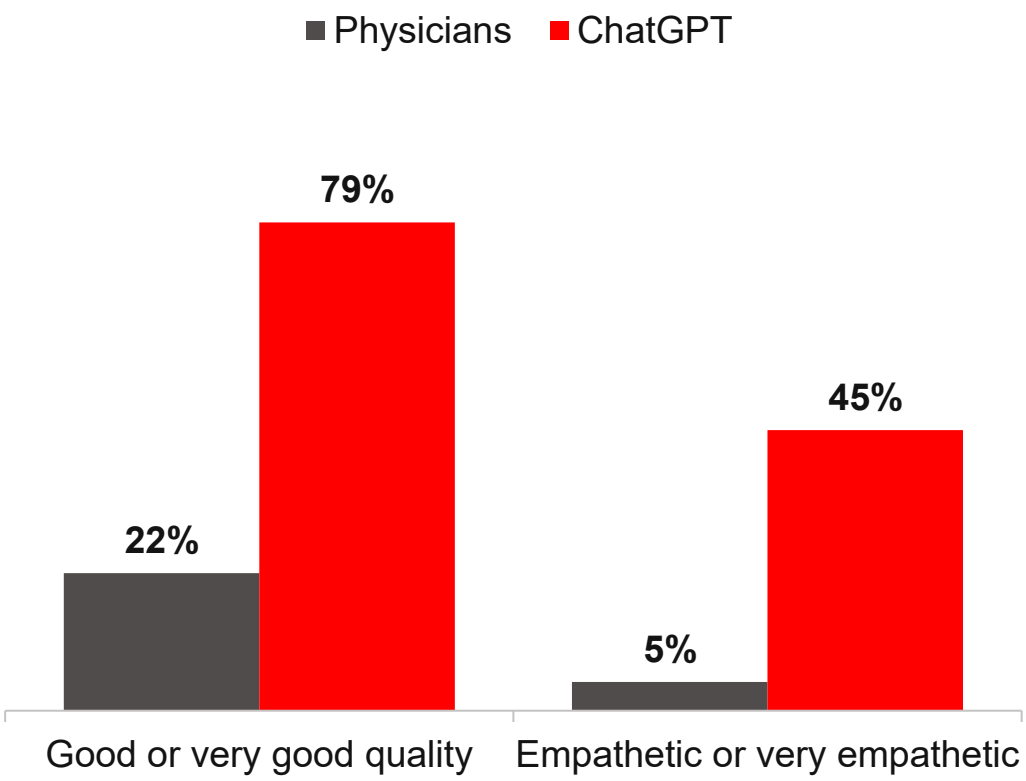


+10–15% output

Why? Observation makes people manage impressions, not the task

Source: Bernstein (2012)

Doctors vs ChatGPT, rated blind



78.6%

of blind ratings preferred the chatbot

×10

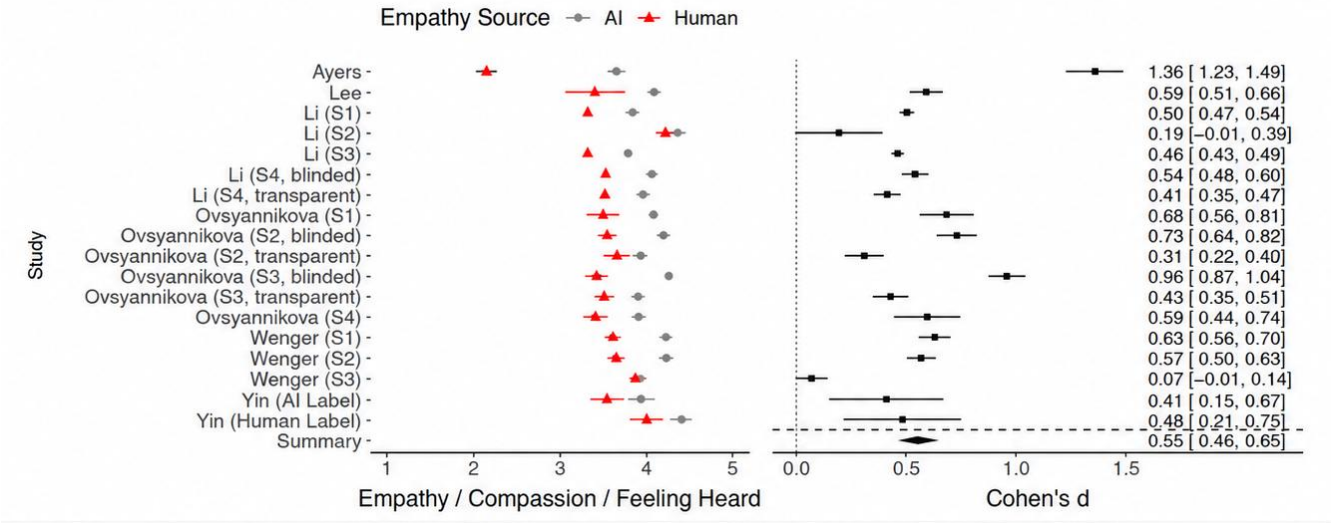
more often rated empathetic

Compared with what?
A doctor at the end of a long shift (like Arie at 1 a.m.)

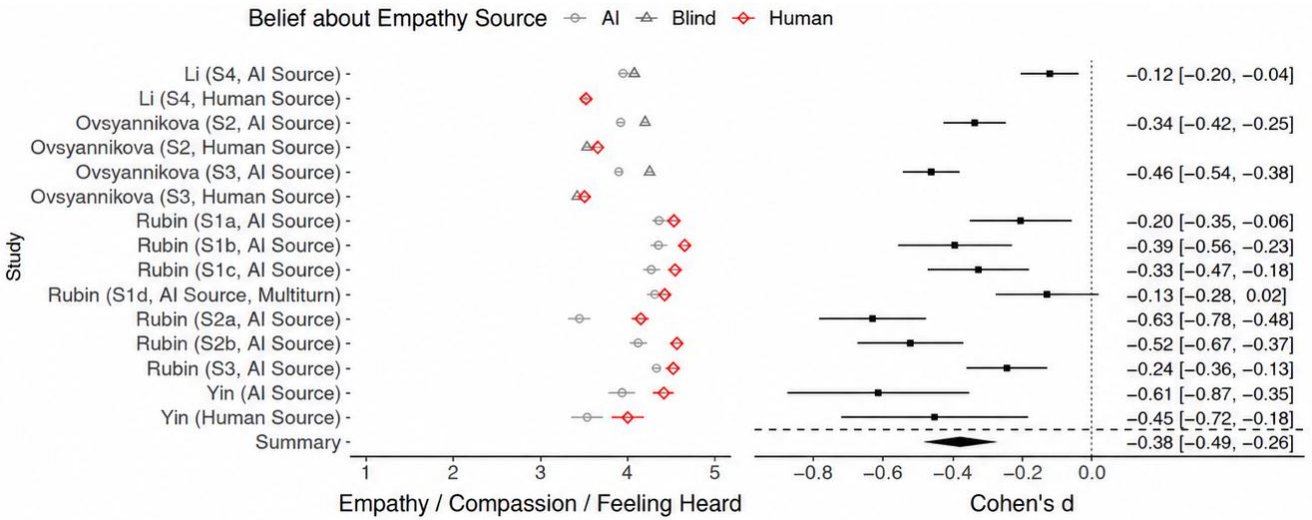
Source: Ayers et al. (2023)

AI responses are rated as more empathic...

AI responses are seen as more emphatic...



...until people learn that they were written by AI



The forgotten last line

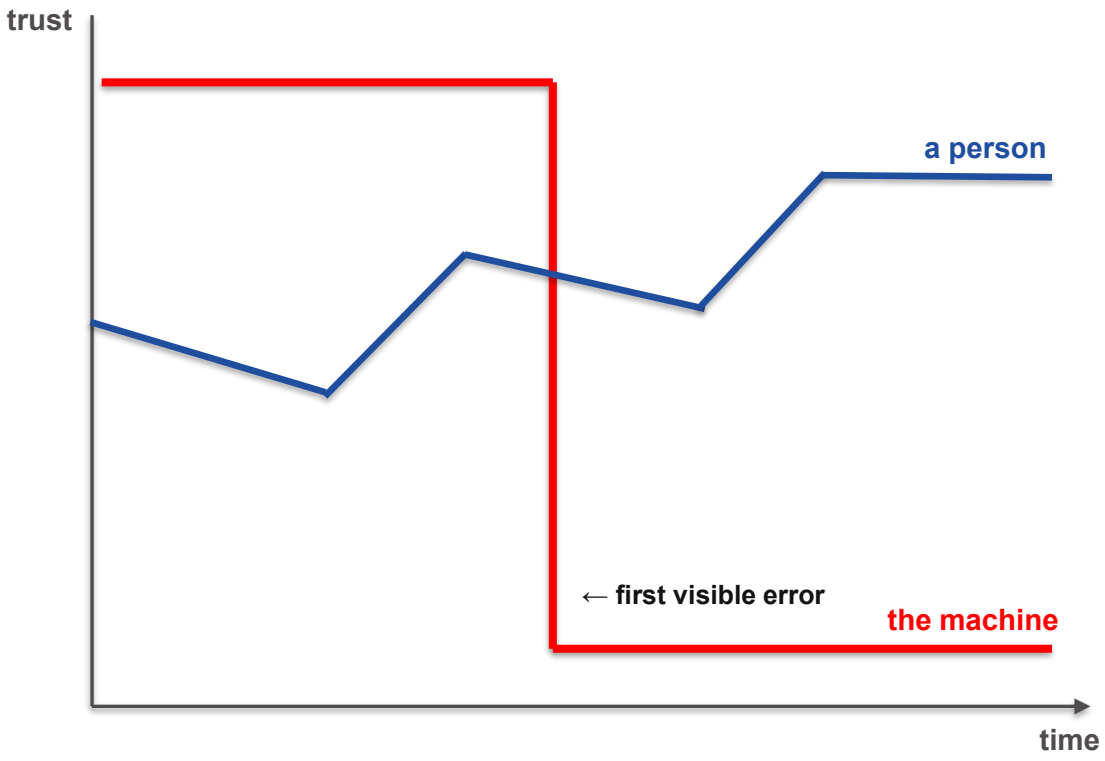
After your big presentation, your boss sends a warm email congratulating you.

At the bottom you read:

"Would you like me to make the tone slightly sharper (more 'firm correction') or slightly warmer (more 'mentorship with a gentle reminder') depending on how you want this person to walk away feeling?"

Source: Hafenbrädl (2026)

We forgive humans, not machines



Algorithm APPRECIATION

Before any error, people follow the algorithm more

Algorithm AVERSION

After seeing the model err once, people drop it

...even after seeing their own bigger errors

Source: Dietvorst et al. (2015); Logg et al. (2019)

How are you leading with AI?

The last time AI gave you something wrong or weak, what did you do?

Fix the answer
or
Ask yourself why you asked it that in the first place

Single loop, double loop



Single loop (do the same thing, better)

Write the email faster.

Run the status meeting shorter.

AI makes this almost free.



Double loop (ask why we do it at all)

Why five hours of status meetings?

Why five drafts of every email?

This is leadership.

Source: Argyris (1977)

How are your teams using AI?

"Workslop"

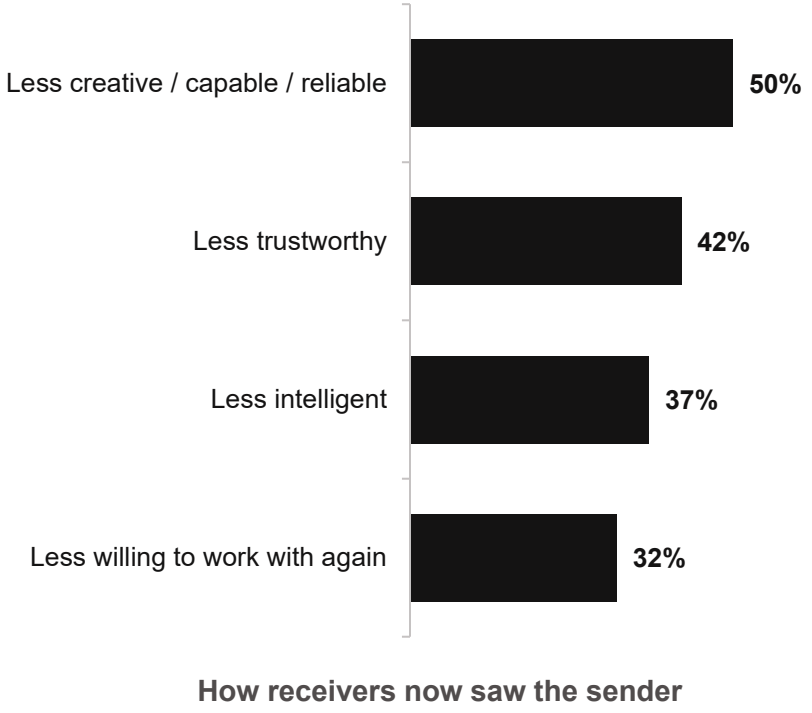
"AI-generated work content that masquerades as good work,
but lacks the substance to meaningfully advance a given task."

How it Works:

Someone uses AI to avoid thinking.

The thinking is transferred to the receiver (read, check, redo, ask).

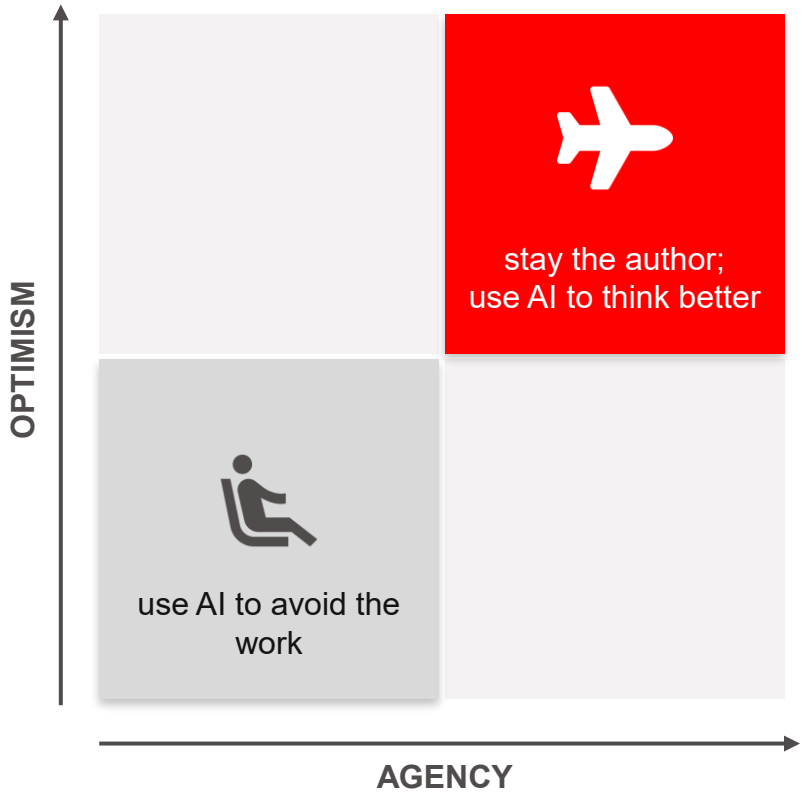
The reciever feels annoyed, confused and offended



The receivers did not complain Nobody told the sender.

Source: Kot Niederhoffer et al. (2025)

Pilots and passengers



Has your team agreed on the rules for AI?

Delegate: What can AI do—and what must you own?

Disclose: When must you tell others you used AI?

Stay human: Where is human judgment essential?

Verify: What must you check before calling the work “finished”?

Which rule is least clear in your team?

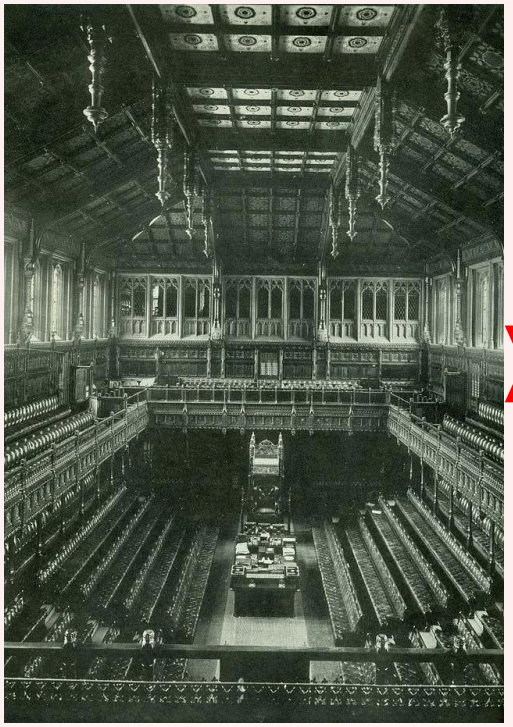
When reviewing AI-assisted work, ask:

- Walk me through your thinking
- What did you challenge, change, and verify?

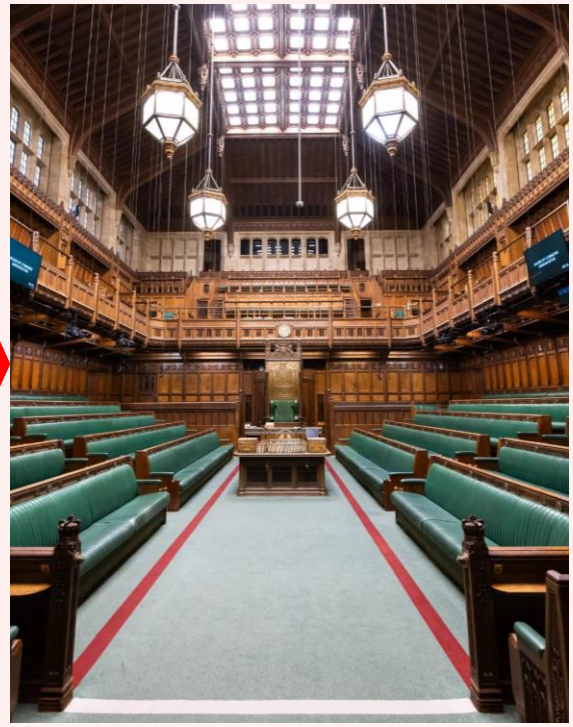
Source: BetterUp Labs & Stanford Social Media Lab (2025); Niederhoffer et al. (2025)

"We shape our buildings; thereafter they shape us."





“Rebuild it as it was” (Oblong and too small for every member: big debates feel crowded)



The room shapes the politics (Two sides face each other; changing party means crossing the floor)

Arie is not choosing a tool.
She is choosing the house she will live in as a leader.

Which part of your leadership would you never delegate?
And are you doing it yourself today?


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